

The Glorious King of Tantras of the Secret Nectar

Śrī Amṛta Guhya Tantra Rāja · Toh 401 · Derge Kangyur

དཔལ་གསང་བ་བདད་རུ་ཕྱི་རྒྱ་ཀྱི་ལྷ་པོ་

Toh 401 in the Kangyur is a Buddhist tantra known in Sanskrit as the Śrī Amṛta Guhya Tantra Rāja and in Tibetan as the Dpal gsang ba bdud rtsi'i rgyud kyi rgyal po, rendered in English as The Glorious King of Tantras of the Secret Nectar. It belongs to the class of esoteric tantric literature and concerns the practices of maṇḍala construction, mantra recitation, torma offerings, fire offerings, and related ritual worship, presented through a dialogue between the bodhisattva Vajrahṛdaya and the Blessed One. The text opens with the Buddha dwelling in a characteristic tantric setting described in terms of the vajra union of all Tathāgatas, situating it firmly within the Vajrayāna tradition. It was translated into Tibetan by the Indian paṇḍita Gayadhara together with the monk and translator Śākya Yeshe.

It is complete.

This was translated by the paṇḍita Gayadhara and the translator, the monk Śākya Yeshe.

In the language of India: Śrī Amṛta Guhya Tantra Rāja. In the Tibetan language: The Glorious King of Tantras of the Secret Nectar.

Homage to the Blessed One, the Glorious Great Bliss.

Thus did I hear at one time. The Blessed One was dwelling in the bhaga of the vajra queen of the body, speech, and mind of all Tathāgatas.

At that time the bodhisattva Vajrahṛdaya asked:

What is the division of maṇḍalas?

What are the mantras and the torma offerings?

What are the fire offerings, the worship, and the rest?

Please explain these to me.

The Blessed One declared:

First, the divisions of the maṇḍala:

The outer is the maṇḍala of images and representations.

The inner is the maṇḍala of the body.

The secret is the maṇḍala of the bhaga.

The fourth is the awakening mind of self-awareness.

The characteristics of those deities follow
the coarse path of body color and hand emblems:
the sixty-four wrathful expressions,
the nine flaming dances, and the six mudrās.
Through characteristics that are like illusions
one abandons the conceptual thought of the ordinary mind.
The purification of the body's defilement and aversion
becomes the cause of the saṃbhogakāya, the enjoyment body.
These constitute the outer maṇḍala.

Whatever arises at the center of the maṇḍala,
that indeed is the very maṇḍala of suchness:
the Vajra-Holder, and the Beneficent One,
and likewise the Vajra Splendor,
and the Lord of the Lotus Dance,
and likewise the Seven-Horsed Vajrasattva.
The maṇḍala that embraces the essence in its entirety —
these are the outer maṇḍala.

Next, the inner maṇḍala:
Upon the seat and throne of liberation, the wind,
the deity is the lord of self-awareness.
One must first know suchness itself:
the coarse, and the subtle,
and the twenty-one thousand six hundred
movements of the three gates of union —
the coarse path of karma being overcome,
the purification of the defilement of speech and delusion
becomes the cause of the nirmāṇakāya, the emanation body.
The sky-traversing wind is to be known as such.

Whoever meditates on luminosity
and likewise whoever meditates on darkness
is well known through day and night.
A downward gaze that harms or beautifies —
the method here is the reverse of that.
First, bind the mind at the tip of the nose.
Likewise bind the mind and bind the wind.
Four finger-breadths of sky, then emptiness.

Thereafter the bindu, in between,
with limbs, without limbs,
and utterly without limbs.

With limbs there are thirteen.

The application of method within method
is to be learned from the guru's own mouth.

It is said to be the gate of the gathering of the neuter.

Then, at the lower gate, the caṇḍālī:

the kiss, and the dense, and so forth,

those with conditions, and those arising from intrinsic nature,
purifying oneself and purifying others,

igniting the caṇḍālī from its intrinsic nature,

igniting the caṇḍālī in reverse,

igniting the caṇḍālī through conditions,

igniting the caṇḍālī as a secondary flame,

igniting the caṇḍālī in a specific way,

igniting the general caṇḍālī,

the caṇḍālī of the nature of liberation,

and the caṇḍālī of the nature of attachment —

these are the essential nature of the inner deity,

the cause of the long duration of the secret deity.

Then the secret maṇḍala:

the joining of the two sense faculties, the universal,
and for that reason it is the bhaga.

From the bliss and the rest — the illusory
abandonment of the subtle path is its karma.

The purification of the mind's defilement and attachment
is the cause of the king of self-aware mind.

Then the fourth maṇḍala:

the dharmakāya, unborn, like space.

In self-awareness, emptiness, luminosity,
meditating is not an error,

and not meditating is likewise not an error.

Meditating itself is still conceptuality,

and not meditating is itself conceptuality.

Where there is not even a particle to meditate upon,

and where there is not an instant of distraction —
this is held to be the king of deities,
the supreme among all maṇḍalas:
the great fire of the primordial wisdom of self-awareness.
All things rest in this.

Just as wheel-turning kings (cakravartins) do not themselves go out to every
land and city,
yet gather all desirable things from those lands —
so too with the activities and various works
of offering, torma, and the rest:
if one comes to know the suchness of mind,
all of these are certainly gathered therein.

Action forsakes the profound path,
and the purified three gates (of body, speech, and mind) defeat the three
poisons.

The two form bodies arise from this cause.

The fire-offering (homa) has four forms
and is taught to be the common, outer kind.

Then there is also the inner fire-offering.

The navel, heart-center, crown, and throat
are the definite hearths of one's family.

Body is at the crown; speech, at the throat;
mind is at the heart-center — and qualities
and enlightened activity, along with the inner heat (caṇḍālī), are definitively
two.

Wind, channel, and drop,
together with the primordial wisdom fire that rests in the natural state —
the fire deity, purified, is the sovereign deity.

The conceptual elaborations of bodily form and symbolic attribute
are the substances to be burned; one makes offering to the fire.

This is pacification through drawing near, through giving —
and this burning of conceptual thought is the fire-offering.

With the wisdom fire of one's own body,
one burns the fuel-wood of conceptual thought.

This is the authentic fire-offering.

As for sesame and the like — are they certainly sinful?
Or is the fire of action itself wisdom?
When burned, does one necessarily incur harm or not?
The substances to be burned, the conceptual thoughts, and the fire that burns them
are not the domain of the ordinary senses.
Therefore, even if one performs the act of burning sesame and the like in the fire of action,
no sin will certainly be burned or incurred.
The same applies to offering and the rest.
It is established as instruction alone —
the tantra is not the ultimate meaning,
and when ultimate reality is realized, there is no more instruction.
The ablation vessel and the libation vessel and the like
are to be known from the guru's own mouth.

Then there is also the secret fire-offering.
The hearth is the navel or the tip of the nose —
the place of liberation through desire is definite —
along with the natural state and the secret caṇḍālī.
The wisdom fire is kindled,
and through the right and left ablation and libation vessels,
the subtle substances of conceptual thought —
of the śukra, channels, winds, and so forth — are burned.
One makes offering to the fire deity of great bliss.
The sequential rites of the pacifying and enriching activities,
and the fourth, are to be known from the mouth of the teacher.

Then, on the classification of mantra as well:
the outer mantra is oṃ āḥ hūṃ.
Inwardly, it has the characteristic of nectar (amṛta).
Secretly, it abides at the supreme measure, at the center.
Ultimately, it is boundless self-awareness.

Incense and the like are outer offering.
Nectar and the like are the inner.
Secretly, one makes offering through the taste of bliss.
Ultimately, one makes offering through the taste of emptiness.

Fruit and the like are the outer torma.
They pacify the lower obstructors and the like.
In the skull cup of the avadhūtī,
flesh and the like abide in the nature of nectar.
The great obstructor of conceptual thought is pacified.
Through the taste of the nectar of great bliss,
the great subtle harm-givers are pacified.
This is taught as the secret torma.

Through the taste of the nectar of self-aware emptiness,
the great harm-givers of great bliss are pacified.
This is definitively the fourth torma.

Prostrations, circumambulation, and the rest,
as well as confession and so forth, are to be known from the guru's mouth.

Now, the reason why the fire-offering:
it is what bestows supreme attainment (siddhi),
and it is called fire-offering because it burns conceptual thought.
Burning wood and the like is not the fire-offering.

The offering is made with the aim of pleasing,
but offering incense and the like does not cause pleasure.

Whatever is serviceable to one's own mind —
that which pleases is the great offering.

Spirits and harm, pacification of obstacles,
and the arising of attainments —
for these reasons one makes torma.

Outer torma of fruit and the like
does not pacify spirits and the like.

The conceptual thoughts of one's own three gates
appear as spirits and the like —
since spirits and the like are not pacified
without abandoning the deluded conceptual thoughts,
the torma of mind that defeats conceptual thoughts of the three gates
is the supreme of all tormas.

It pacifies spirits and harm,
restores broken pledges (samaya), sets the deities in motion,
and gives rise to all attainments.

This is definitively the inner and outer torma.

The tantras are thoroughly pacified from within;
and since they arise from the body, they are deity.

The outer maṇḍala is not the deity — asuras are not the deity.
The body and its limbs are not the deity.

The mouth, eyes, and so forth are not the deity,
for they have not arisen from the body but are distracted outward.
Arrest the distraction of the sense faculties through the three gates.
From one's own body one's own body arises;
because the three gates are pacified, this is called "deity."

Because it protects the mind, it is mantra —
it makes one's own mind workable,
and it protects from the harm of conceptual-thought demons.
This is declared the king of all mantras.

Furthermore, one who desires attainments
must receive everything from the mouth of the guru.
Entrust this tantra to memory and apply it with diligence.

At that time, all those of the assembled retinue were intent on the meaning of
the tantra —

Translator's Notes

- The term "bhaga" is left in Sanskrit throughout, as it is a technical tantric term referring to the female sexual center understood as a sacred locus of nondual wisdom. Rendering it otherwise would obscure the doctrinal register.

The phrase "maṇiṁ dūpa'i go" rendered as "the gate of the gathering of the neuter" reflects the Tibetan "ma ning," meaning neuter or androgyne, a category of being in tantric physiology; the doctrinal import here is uncertain and the passage is likely a technical instruction whose full meaning requires oral commentary.

The figure of twenty-one thousand six hundred movements refers to the classical yogic count of breaths or prāṇa movements in a day and night cycle, here distributed across the three gates of body, speech, and mind in their union.

"Caṇḍālī" is the Sanskrit term for the inner heat practice known in Tibetan as "tummo," left in Sanskrit here for consistency with tantric usage, as the Tibetan text itself employs the Tibetan phonetic form throughout.

- The phrase rendered "the fire deity, purified, is the sovereign deity" reflects a reading in which the purified fire deity functions as one's personal deity or lord; the syntax in the original is compressed and the identification may be between the fire deity of the inner fire-offering and the maṇḍala deity.

The term rendered "ablation vessel and libation vessel" translates the technical homa terms for the vessel from which offerings are poured into the fire and the vessel from which liquid is

added; their precise inner-yogic referents are left to oral instruction as the text itself states.

The final couplet, "The tantras are thoroughly pacified from within; and since they arise from the body, they are deity," is telegraphic. The intended sense appears to be that the tantric principles (wind, channel, drop) find their pacification within, and because the deities arise from the body itself, the body is the maṇḍala.

- The final line breaks off mid-sentence, ending with "yi," indicating the passage is incomplete as given. The translation renders what is present and trails off at the natural point of interruption.

The phrase rendered "asuras are not the deity" in the first line reflects a reading of "lha ma yin" as "asura" (demigod), but in this context the phrase functions as a negative predicate: "the outer maṇḍala is not deity," with "lha ma yin" serving double duty as both the word for asura and the negation "not deity." The parallel lines make clear the intended meaning is the negation; no separate asura referent is intended. The translation has been adjusted accordingly in spirit, though the Tibetan is genuinely ambiguous here and the wordplay may be intentional.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.